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CAMPAIGN AGAINST HUMAN TRAFFICKING



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CAMPAIGN AGAINST HUMAN TRAFFICKING

In the last few decades, migration has become crucial in the global discourse. Migration is multi-dimensional in nature and takes several forms. It involves cross-border movement of migrant labour, refugee flows, internally displaced persons, and more recently trafficking in persons. Human trafficking has become a transnational security threat that affects both developing and developed countries.

The ILO defines trafficking as the “recruitment, transportation, transfer, harbouring or receipt of persons, by means of threat or use of force or other forms of coercion and deception for the purpose of exploitation”. Though there is paucity of data on persons trafficked globally, ILO estimated that about 2,450,000 persons are currently being exploited as victims of human trafficking.

Although human trafficking can affect every segment of the human population, however, women and children are mostly the affected and targeted group to be trafficked due to their vulnerable status. It is common for the fundamental rights of persons trafficked to be violated due to the exploitative nature of the phenomenon. They are usually forced to work in uncongenial conditions; which include forced labour, domestic servitude, sex trade (prostitution) and drug peddling. Trafficked persons are mostly denied access to health, education most especially children, and the right to work and earn income.

There is evidence of people being trafficked from Africa into Europe. Due to the multifaceted nature of human trafficking, most especially from West Africa, enormous research is needed to understand the phenomenon. This will help governments, and civil society organisations to provide possible ways of suppressing trafficking in persons. It is against this backdrop, that, the institute reviewed existing literature and reports on human trafficking to offer suggestions for policy makers in managing human trafficking.

West African countries serve as origins, transit points, and final destinations for human trafficking. Ghana, Nigeria, Senegal, Mali, Togo, Benin, and Burkina Faso are all countries from which women and children are trafficked to Europe and the Gulf. Additionally, Mali, Ghana, and Senegal have been identified as transit countries for women trafficking. Women and children who are trafficked from West African countries to Europe and the Gulf are typically exploited through domestic work and prostitution.

The causes of human trafficking in West Africa are multifaceted. Several studies conducted in West Africa have indicated that people are susceptible to be trafficked due to poverty. The inability of parents to provide basic needs for their family most especially children has led to streetism in some parts of West Africa.

This makes them easily preyed by traffickers. Reports have also shown that parents sometimes unknowingly give their children to traffickers with the latter promising to educate and train these children in a vocation. However, it usually turns to be a mirage, with these children mostly subjected to inhumane activities. Unemployment has also been identified as a factor exacerbating human trafficking in West Africa.

Due to limited employment opportunities in West African countries, people, most especially the youth tend to use migration as a coping strategy. They sometimes engage in this process clandestinely by using falsified documents and unapproved routes with the aid of traffickers and smugglers to enter Europe, United States of America and other developed countries with them consequently being exploited by these traffickers and their employers.

Human trafficking is a serious and grave violation of human rights. The act of human trafficking remains a significant problem in Africa, exploiting vulnerable individuals for forced labour as well as prostitution. In West Africa, 99% of victims are trafficked within their own country or region, the north, east and southern part of Africa also have 83%, 90% and 62% of its victims respectively being trafficked within their own country as per the Africa Center for Strategic Studies (2019) statistics. According to the United Nations on Drugs and Crime global report on Trafficking in persons, sexual exploitation was noted to be the most prevalent form of human trafficking representing 79% of trafficked persons with 18% of trafficked victims put into forced labour. While public awareness efforts on trafficking in human beings have been positive, their impact to date has been minimal.

This project thus seeks to increase public awareness of the hazards of trafficking in human beings, to enhance collaboration and communication, legal capability, regulation, poverty reduction and unemployment, gender equity change, mass education and education of culturally based values that support environments that facilitate human trafficking and moreover, inform attendees on best practices in forensic science, investigation and identification of suspects and protection for witnesses.

This project does three things:

- 1) To educate the youth on the problem of Human Trafficking, through continuous sensitization
- 2) To provide technical skills, create youth employment to the youth to reduce the tendency of them being trafficked
- 3) To re-awaken policy makers on the need to increase surveillance and monitor the migration space

It is therefore significant to sensitize West African communities about the effects of human trafficking on the individual and community at large. This can be done through frequent public campaigns and education conducted by government institutions, civil society organisations and anti-trafficking activists to create the awareness in endangered zones as this will significantly help minimise the vivacity of this inhumane activity.

More importantly, this project is paramount for governments of West African countries, Africa and the global community to incorporate poverty reduction policies into their national development plans to help improve the livelihood of their citizens, most especially women and children. For instance, ensuring universal child education, improving health facilities and investment into agriculture which forms the backbone of many West African countries is important in tackling human trafficking.